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USEFUL IDIOMS FOR IELTS WITH EXAMPLES



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Introduction

Idioms are used in the day-to-day language, while some idioms are common across cultures and languages. For a language learner, it is important to use the correct phrase in the proper order. This is also known as collocation.

The IELTS Speaking examination evaluates how well applicants can use idiomatic language for bands seven and upwards. The aspirant is examined on the common idioms for IELTS Speaking in the exam. Thus, they must know how to use and pronounce these idioms correctly.



What are **Idioms?**

An idiom is a phrase or expression generally having a non-literal meaning–the meaning cannot be directly understood by reading each word.



List of Common Idioms **for IELTS**

Some Common Idioms for IELTS Speaking Test with Meanings

Given below are some commonly-used idioms in IELTS speaking test with their usage in a question and answer form:

Idioms	Meaning	Question	Usage (with Answers)
It makes my blood boil	To be disgusted and infuriated	How well do you get on with your friends?	My friends are my family. I am a happy and outgoing social person; therefore, I have a lot of good friends, except one. I mainly do not like her because she yells and mistreats me. Even the thought of her **makes my blood boil.**
To have a whale of a time	To rejoice	Can you tell us something about your hometown?	Start the answer by saying that your native place can be either India/ Singapore, and that's a fantastic destination with a cross-cultural environment. One cannot get bored in Singapore/India as there are engaging activities for every age group. My entire childhood has been a memorable journey. Anyone visiting the city can **have a whale of a time.**
On the dot	Exactly at the right time	Tell us about one habit of yours that everyone should have.	I am quite a disciplined person with many good habits. To be precise, I would speak about my punctuality. I feel everyone should be punctual. Whenever I am supposed to reach any place, I am always **on the dot.** I do not make delays unnecessarily, which has helped me in life.

Find my feet	To be comfortable with something	Why did you take up this particular subject?	Mathematics was never my strength. Even then, I took up the subject for my graduation, and there is a long story behind it. I was weak at it in my school days, but I always tried to understand it better. Slowly, with my father's help, **I found my feet** and got better at it. He helped by giving me extra time. Soon, it became my favorite subject, and now I am pursuing it further.
Set in their ways	It means not wanting to change	How would you describe your parents?	My parents are very cooperative in my choices and decisions. They have always helped me become independent. However, they are not very welcoming to a few modern thoughts. They are **set in their ways**, in that respect. It creates some clashes among us as they always have their own experience.
Burn the midnight oil	To stay up till late for a meaningful reason	What was the reason behind having such good academic scores?	I always wished to study abroad after high school, so I pushed myself. It was not easy for me to reach here as I had to **burn the midnight oil** every day. I am not an early person, and I usually get my work done at night.
Down in the dumps	Being disappointed and sad	How many colleges/ universities did you apply to?	I submitted my application to eight colleges, and I was a bit **down in the dumps** with the results as I got five rejections.
To be over the moon	To feel fulfilled and happy	What did you do on your last birthday?	My last birthday was the best. I was **over the moon** because my brother visited us after six years in the USA. It was an emotional yet amazing day. My parents arranged a surprise birthday party in the evening, and I was showered with several gifts.

Now that you know some common and valuable idioms for the IELTS Speaking test practice them regularly for a good band score.

A-Z of English Idioms

Idioms Starting With A

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
A blessing in disguise	A positive thing that isn't recognized until later	I failed the Maths test during my pre-boards. It proved a **blessing in disguise** as I pushed myself hard to achieve a distinction in my final exams.
A drop in the ocean	Small part of something much bigger	The budget sanctioned for marketing the product is just a **drop in the ocean.** We need more than this to increase sales.
Against the clock	Do something as fast as possible and try to finish it before a certain time	The team was working **against the clock** to finish the project on time.
All in the same boat	In the same difficult situation as someone else	Sam said that he hated his job, to which Joel added that they were **all in the same boat.**
Actions speak louder than words	It is better to do something rather than just talk about it	She keeps saying she loves me, but **actions speak louder than words.**
A mare's nest	Difficult and confusing situation	The cure announced for the disease was merely another **mare's nest.**
A hot potato	A topic that is very controversial	The issue of gun control is a political **hot potato** in the United States.
An arm and a leg	Very expensive	Purchasing that house cost me **an arm and a leg.**
At the drop of a hat	Immediately, instantly	We're all packed and ready to go; we can leave at the **drop of a hat.**

Idioms Starting With B

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Between the devil and deep sea	Stuck between two awful choices; having two poor alternatives	I can see you're caught between the **devil and the deep sea**; if you support your son, your partner will be hurt.
Be sick to death of something/doing something	To be angry and bored because something unpleasant has been happening for too long	I am **sick to death** of being told that this is our fault.
Be all ears	Eager and ready to listen	She had expected him to **be all ears** when she told him about her wedding plans.
Bent out of shape	Angry or agitated	Jill got **bent out of shape** after his train was canceled.
Bump into	To meet someone accidentally	I **bumped into** my childhood friend while I was roaming around the streets of Dehradun.
Bite the hand that feeds you	Hurt or upset someone who is helping you	Don't tell her what you really think of her if she's helping you with your English! Don't **bite the hand that feeds you.**
By the skin of your teeth	Just almost making it, by a very narrow margin	He escaped the police **by the skin of his teeth.**

Idioms Starting With C

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
(On the) cutting edge	The most modern, up-to-date process, or product/equip-ment	My new company has always been **on the cutting edge** of the new electronic media.
Call it a day	End the job for the day	I'm getting a bit tired now, let's **call it a day.**
Catch his eye	Something or some-one very beautiful in appearance	While I was walking today, beautiful pottery **caught my eye.**
Change one's mind	To change a decision or opinion	He wasn't going to come, but at the last minute, he **changed his mind.**
Chicken scratch	The handwriting that is crammed or illegi-ble	My calligraphy is so illegible my mother calls it **chicken scratch.**
Chill out	Relax, calm down	We're just **chilling out** and watching some series on Sunday morning.
Crash course	A quick lesson	This project turned out to be a c**rash course** in data science for her.
Chip on his shoulder	To have an angry or unpleasant attitude	He has had a **chip on his shoulder** ever since he didn't get the appraisal.
Cut to the chase	Leave out all the unnecessary details and get to the point	I didn't have long to talk, so **I cut to the chase** and asked whether she was still married.

Idioms Starting With D

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Down to earth	Someone who is practical and realistic	Everyone liked her **down-to-earth** approach to life.
Dutch courage	Courage inspired by alcohol	He needed some **Dutch courage** before telling her wife about what happened.
Driving up the wall	To make (someone) irritated, angry, or crazy	He's so uncooperative - he's beginning to **drive me up the wall.**
Dollars to doughnuts	To emphasize one's certainty	**Dollars to doughnuts** that John will be late for today's meeting.
Deliver the goods	Provide something which is promised or expected	People doubt that the new minister can really **deliver the goods.**
Dice with death	Take serious risks.	You're **dicing with death** driving at that speed on icy roads.
Dash something off	To write (something) in a very quick and hurried way	I **dashed off** a quick letter.
Darken someone's door	If you darken someone's door, you come as an unwanted or unwelcomed visitor	She told him to leave her house and never **darken her door again.**

Idioms Starting With E

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Easy as pie	Very easy	The results are sure to be good this time since the exam was **as easy as a pie.**
Explore all avenues	Investigate every possible means to find a solution or to achieve the desired outcome	I **explored all avenues** to find a dress similar to the one Taylor Swift wore at her concert.
Early bird	Someone who gets up early	Sam is an **early bird** and she manages her schedule really well.
Earn your stripes	Deserve a position, status, or reputation through work or achievements	She is yet to **earn her stripes** as an anchor.
Eat like a horse	To eat in large amounts	Joe is so thin, despite **eating like a horse.**
Elephant in the room	Obvious issue that no one is talking about	I don't want to ask the question, but it is the big **elephant in the room.**

Idioms Starting With F

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Fill in for someone	Do someone's work while the responsible party is away	She will **fill in for him** while he's at the meeting.
Fresh/clean out	Have sold or used up the last of something	The shopkeeper said that they are **fresh out** of green vegetables.

Full of beans	A person who is lively, active, and healthy	Upon hearing the good news about her child, Mary was **full of beans.**
Far cry from	Very different from something/someone	The apartment they live in now is a **far cry from** the huge mansion they once owned.
For ages	For a very long time	This elaborate deception fooled his family **for ages.**
Fingers crossed	To wish for luck for someone or something	We're keeping our **fingers crossed** that the weather stays nice.
Follow one's heart	Do what you feel right	I decided to **follow my heart** and take up acting as my professional course.

Idioms Starting With G

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Get a kick out of	To get excitement or pleasure from an event or thought	I really **get a kick out of** watching my two-year-old nephew.
Get the ball rolling	Start doing something, especially something big	Sam wanted to have a nice garden this summer so she **got the ball rolling** by planting some seeds in little pots.
Get on the nerves	To annoy someone	My roommate's girlfriend **gets on my nerves** when she talks in a winy, baby voice.
Get/jump on the bandwagon	Join a popular trend	So many people are trying to quit social media that and I might as well **jump on the bandwagon** by quitting.
Give (lend) somebody a hand	To give some form of assistance with a task	Could you **give me a hand** with these suitcases?
Go the extra mile	To make an extra effort	My mother-in-law **went the extra mile** to take care of me during my pregnancy.

Give the benefit of doubt	To decide whether you will believe someone or something	She said she was late because her flight was canceled, and her manager **gave the benefit of the doubt.**
Got up on the wrong side of the bed	To refer to someone who is having a bad day	Joe, you should avoid arguing with your boss today as she **got up on the wrong side of the bed** this morning.
Give the best shot	Try one's hardest	The latest project is not easy, but I'm going to **give it my best shot.**
Get out of the hand	Situation out of control	It was the end of term and the students were **getting a little out of hand.**

Idioms Starting With H

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Hit the hay	Go to bed	After working all day long, it was time to **hit the hay.**
Hit the nail on the head	To be right about something	He **hit the nail on the head** when he predicted that it was going to rain.
Hear on the grapevine	To hear rumors about something or someone	I **heard on the grapevine** that my teammate got the promotion.
Have/get mixed feelings about something	To be uncertain about something	She was having **mixed feelings** about her trip to Europe.
Have a chin-wag	Have a long conversation between friends	They went for a ride out in the country and **had a good old chin-wag.**
I hit the ceiling	To lose one's temper or become extremely angry	**I hit the ceiling** when I got to know about my crashed car.
Hold your horses	To be patient	**Hold your horses,** you would receive an offer letter
Hard feelings	Emotion of being upset or offended	After the breakup Emma had **hard feelings** about whatever happened.

Idioms Starting With I

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
In deep water	To get into serious trouble	The political party **is in deep water** after their candidate had lied in the report.
In high spirits	Extremely happy	All the children were **in high spirits** on the last day of school.
In the heat of the moment	Say or do it without thinking because you are very angry or excited	He really didn't mean what he said about you **in the heat of the moment.**
In the nick of time	Not too late, but very close	He arrived at the wedding in **the nick of time.**
It takes two to tango	Both people involved in a bad situation are responsible for it	Don't blame me for the argument. **It takes two to tango!**
It's a small world	Unexpected meeting with someone	**It's a small world** as I met my child-hood friend in theater.
In perfect shape	Physically fit	Sarah was soon back in **perfect shape** after pregnancy.

Idioms Starting With K

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Keep an eye on	To monitor a situa-tion, not forget about it	The manager **kept an eye on** the new joiners.
Keep one's chin up	Remain brave, and keep on trying	He's still **keeping his chin up** despite all his health problems.
Keep something at bay	Keep something away	This kid is very problematic; I am doing my best to **keep him at bay.**

Keep your nose to the grindstone	Continue to put forward a good effort.	You'll do well at college if you **just keep your nose to the grindstone.**
Kill two birds with one stone	To accomplish two different things at the same time.	**I killed two birds with one stone** by picking the kids up on the way to the supermarket.
Know something inside out	To be totally familiar with	I'm going to ace this exam. I **know the test paper inside out.**
Kicked the bucket	Died	Every one of us will **kick the bucket** someday.
Keyed up	Excited or nervous about something	Sam was **keyed up** for her new job.
Knock it off	To stop doing some-thing annoying	**Knock it off!** You're making so much noise I can't concentrate.
Know on which side your bread is buttered	Know what is to one's advantage	She pretends to be unbiased, but **she knows on which side her bread is buttered.**

Idioms Starting With L

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Last straw	The final problem in a series of problems	It had been a difficult week, so when the car broke down, it was the **last straw.**
Leave well alone	To not try to change something that is good enough	You should take my advice and **leave well alone.**
Lend an ear	To listen carefully and in a friendly way to someone	**Lend me your ears**, and I will tell you about my adventurous trip to New Zealand.
Let sleeping dogs lie	To not talk about things that have caused prob-lems in the past, or not try to change a situation because you might cause problems	I wanted to tell her what I thought, but then I decided to **let sleeping dogs lie.**
Live up to the hype	To be as good as people hoped it would be	I hope this new film is as good as critics are saying **and lives up to the hype.**

Idioms Starting With M

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Make a fuss over	Overly caring for someone/something	He **made a fuss over** the new car he brought from his salary.
Miss the boat	Miss an opportunity	She **missed the boat** when she did not apply for the job within the deadline.
Make a fast buck	Earn money without much effort	Tom is always ready to **make a fast buck** by selling his old clothes.
Make a mountain out of a molehill	To exaggerate the severity of a situation; to make a lot of fuss about nothing	Why are you **making a mountain out of a molehill?** It's a small injury.
Make heavy weather of something	Have unnecessary difficulty in dealing with	Why do we **make such heavy weather** of learning languages?

Idioms Starting With N

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Next to nothing	To cost very little	You won't believe this but this purse cost me **next to nothing.**
Not playing with a full deck	Someone who lacks intelligence	She was **not playing with a full deck** during her quiz game.
Now and then	Happens sometimes, not regularly	After moving to California, the two best friends meet every **now and then.**
No rocket science	Not difficult	Basketball is **not rocket science.** It's about putting the ball in the basket.
Not my cup of tea	Something that is not to your taste	She admits that dancing isn't **every-one's cup of tea.**

Idioms Starting With O

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
(Right) Off the top of my head	Saying something without giving it too much thought or without precise knowledge	I can't give a green go to the project just **off the top of my head.**
On cloud nine	Very happy	He's been **on cloud nine** ever since she agreed to marry him.
On the ball	Active, and aware of things	She really is **on the ball** offering services to the NGO for children.
On the go	Busy/ hard at work	I got a new job this year where **I am on the go** all the time.
Once in a blue moon	Happens very rarely	I'm very careful about what I eat, so it's only **once in a blue moon** I eat fast food.

Idioms Starting With P

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Pull the wool over someone's eyes	Deceive someone into thinking well of them	His mother thought **she is pulling the wool over his eyes** by keeping him away from the academy.
Put all your eggs in one basket	Put all your money or effort into one thing	He ended up **putting all his eggs in one basket** when he bought the investment scheme.
Put yourself in somebody's shoes	Imagine that you are in somebody's position in order to understand his/her feelings	**Put yourself in my shoes** and then tell me what you would have done for this relationship.
Play ducks and drakes with	Using things recklessly	He **played duck and drakes** at the newly launched cafe yesterday.
Piece of cake	Something easily achieved	I never thought that training him would be a **piece of cake.**
Pull one's weight	Do a fair share of work	If he doesn't start **pulling his weight,** he'll lose his job.
Pass with flying colors	Pass a test with high score	She **passed her 12th board exams** with flying colors.

Idioms Starting With R

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Read my/your/his mind	Guess what somebody is thinking	You **read my mind** as this was the restaurant I wanted to visit for lunch.
Run-of-the-mill	Average, ordinary	I was just a **run-of-the-mill** kind of student during my school time.
Rain cats and dogs	To rain heavily	It was raining **cats and dogs** on Saturday evening.
Read the riot act	Warn or reprimand forcefully or severely	The professor **read the riot act** after the students caused chaos in the class.
Red-letter day	A particularly significant day (personal or sectarian)	It was a **red-letter day** in his life after he cleared the UPSC exam.

Idioms Starting With S

Idioms	Meaning	
See eye to eye	Two (or more people) agree on something	I'm glad that we **see eye to eye** on the project's execution.
Sit on the fence	To stay indecisive	You can't **sit on the fence** any longer, you need to make up your mind.
Swan song	The last piece of work produced by an artist	The singer announced the concert would be her **swan song.**

Idioms Starting With T

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Take with a grain of salt	Consider something to be not completely true or right	You have to **take everything she says with a grain of salt** because she tends to exaggerate.
Taste of your own medicine	Something happens to you or is done to you that you have done to someone else	I don't feel sorry at all that people are calling you names. You're getting a **taste of your own medicine.**
The real McCoy	Genuine	The apples in Shimla's Kothgarh are **the real McCoy.**
The wee hours	After midnight	The brutal raid was carried out in **the wee hours** of the morning.
Throw in the towel	Give up on something/-Accept defeat	Facing a tough maths exam, simply made him **throw in the towel.**
To be up in arms about something	Upset or angry about something	**They're up in arms** about the new management in the organization.
To pick holes in something	To find weak points	The new manager **tries to pick holes** in every task done by his subordinates.
To split hair	To argue unnecessarily	She talks like she is **splitting hair** whenever she talks to her house help.
To fight tooth and nail	Try very hard to get something	He **fought tooth and nail** to win the debate competition.
To strain every nerve	Trying hard	She's **straining every nerve** to get the work finish the project on time.
To turn up one's nose	To refuse	I offered the dog some food, but he **turned his nose up** and walked away.
To put a shoulder to the wheel	Make a strenuous effort	The other team has **to put a shoulder to the wheel** to win the cricket match against India.
To bring the house down	To make everyone laugh	The clown **brought the house down** while singing with his talking horse.
To be on cloud nine	Being extremely happy about something that has happened	**I was on cloud nine** when I got the news from my parents that I got admission to my dream university.

Idioms Starting With U

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
Under the weather	Means that you are sick	I don't feel like hanging out today. I'm feeling a bit **under the weather.**
Up-market	Relatively expensive and designed to appeal to wealthy consumers	Chinese firms have moved steadily **up-market.**
Up-to-the-minute	The very latest or most recent	Traffic reports are **up-to-the-minute** on the map.
Under age	Means being too young to be eligible for something	The cases of **underage** drinking are increasing rapidly.
Under one's belt	- Refers to something that you have learned, mastered, or achieved and is now a part of your experience. -In one's stomach, as food or drink	She now has almost a year experience as a trained kathak dancer **under her belt.**

Idioms Starting With W

Idioms	Meaning	Usage
White elephant	An unprofitable investment, something that is large and unwisely and is a nuisance and /or expensive to maintain	The bar with zero customers has become a **white elephant** to the CEO's wife.
Whole nine yards	Everything or, as far as possible	The mountain trail was a difficult one, but I wanted to go the **whole nine yards.**
Work flat out	Work very hard	He has **worked flat out** for three months to achieve his targets.
Wouldn't be caught dead	Express strong dislike for something	She **wouldn't be caught dead** walking in the sun.
Wait for the ball to drop	To wait in expectation of an occurrence	The kids are bouncing off the walls **waiting for the ball to drop.**

Tips to Learn Idioms **for IELTS**

Understand the Context:

Try to figure out a specific expression or phrase's context. It will aid you in better comprehending and remembering them. As a result, context is crucial. A few other sentences may be used in the same situation. It depends on the rhyme and appropriateness.

Prepare a List:

Try to jot down each unusual idiom you come across, together with its meaning and context. This journal will help review and recall information. Alternatives to a diary or notebook include tablets, cellphones, and computers.

Avoid Cramming:

Idioms are not as simple and enjoyable to learn as most candidates believe. Several of them attempt to study them in a random way. Learn to group them as per their themes.

Visual Correlation:

While memorizing idioms and phrases, link them to tales and use imagery to help you recall them. Learning them with this technique can improve the strength and longevity of your memory.

About upGrad Abroad

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